Is it always sensible to search for a 'non-output controllable indicator' to use as an accountability?

People working in an outcomes-oriented environment can face two, sometimes contradictory, pressures around indicator selection. First, they may be asked to find indicators that are as high up the relevant DoView strategy/outcomes diagram or outcomes framework as possible (i.e. as 'outcome-y' as possible). Meanwhile, outputs (goods or services produced by an initiative) are typically lower down the relevant DoView diagram. So, to find indicators that are as high as possible, government central agencies, funders or others may try to insist that the organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative give them 'indicators that are not outputs'.

The second pressure is that funders or others might, at the same time, also decide that they want to have indicators that are automatically attributable to the organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative. These will, by definition, have to be ones that are controllable by the initiative. As discussed in other tools, indicators measuring controllable boxes in a DoView strategy/outcomes diagram are automatically attributable to an initiative merely by measuring that they have occurred.

This means that the type of indicators being sought by funders are 'non-output controllable indicators'. It should not be assumed that it will always be possible to find one or more of these. Sometimes, non-output controllable indicators can be identified. For instance, if you are running a workshop, the workshop being run will be the output, while an improvement in the workshop participants' knowledge will be the non-output controllable indicator.

However, for other initiatives, it may not be possible to find a non-output controllable (and hence automatically attributable) indicator. Central agencies, purchasers, funders or agencies contracting providers can inadvertently end up demanding such a thing as they push being outcomes-oriented while also focusing on attributing indicators to a particular initiative for accountability purposes. In cases where non-output controllable indicators cannot be located, purchasers/funders demanding that initiatives locate these can create unnecessary confusion and tension between them and suppliers/providers.

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